



HAVING A BALL



PLACE TO WATCH CRICKET EDEN GARDENS, KOLKATA

Most of India's cricket grounds make up in atmosphere what they lack in terms of amenities. Still the toss up for where the best cricket experience in the country can be found, includes some usual heavy-weight names: Punjab Cricket Association's lavish ground in Mohali, the Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bangalore or the MA Chidambaram Stadium in Chennai. Two other grounds in Jaipur's refurbished Sawai Man Singh Stadium and the Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium in the Hyderabad suburb of Uppal are now aiming to be the prototype of the 21st century Indian stadium with glass, granite, spaciousness and working toilets, an amenity that cricket administrators seem to consider an dispensable luxury.

But the best place to watch a cricket game still remains the country's largest ground—Kolkata's Eden Gardens. On a big day, Eden is Indian cricket captured in a small square km area. A vast soup plate of a ground, with a red brick high court peeping over one stand, heaving with crowds that can reach 1,00,000 and make the noise of twice that number, the Eden

Gardens has the magic ability to produce a series of memorable cricket matches. The best seat in there? In the president's box situated on the first floor of the BC Roy club house, not too high and not too low, just behind the bowler's arm, with windows that open so, if needed, you can let some of the uproar in. The hospitality, the price of food, the officious maniacs of the Kolkata Police, the quality of the displays on the wall are all incidental. Eden Gardens remains Indian cricket's high temple. To enjoy it, you must be a true devotee. **by Sharda Ugra**

ON A BIG DAY, EDEN GARDEN IS INDIAN CRICKET CAPTURED IN A SMALL SQUARE KM AREA.

SPECIAL DISH

It is as synonymous with Hyderabad as the Charminar. But Hyderabadi biryani is special when it is cooked right. At the 300-seat Bawarchi restaurant, owners Jaffer Mansoori and Nasir Boloor know fully well that the texture of rice and the purity of the ingredients is vital for taste. So, whether it is the size of the grain, the tenderness of the meat, the right mix of spices, the colour of the saffron or the nature of the fire, all that goes into making biryani is carefully tested and measured. For that distinct flavour, the rice is cooked on firewood unlike other places that have switched to the use of cooking gas. This is because the uniform heat generated by burning wood at a low flame enriches the taste. Bawarchi's popularity has spread way beyond the city. Improved foil packing that helps retain



BIRYANI BAWARCHI, HYDERABAD



APRABHAKARRAO

heat has made biryani buffs take it from Bawarchi to the UAE, the UK, the US and Malaysia besides Indian cities. Mansoori's film connections ensure that Hindi and Telugu film stars are constantly requesting for Bawarchi biryani to be sent to their five-star hotel rooms or to their sets when they are shooting in and around Hyderabad. Regulars include Suneil Shetty, Salman Khan, Sanjay Dutt while Tinu Anand and Naseeruddin Shah prefer to have it in the restaurant that is just off the APSRTC cross-road in Chikkadpally. After all, special traditional food is more enjoyable in an authentic ambience.

by Amarnath K. Menon